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Inequality in Education: A Critical Analysis

W. James JACOB & Donald B. HOLSINGER

Introduction

Several leading development agencies had posited education and equity as key themes at the onset of the 21st century. The United Nation's Millennium Development Goal (MDG) No.2 "Achieve Universal Primary Education" and MDG No.3 "Promote Gender Equality and Empower Women" are devoted to educational attainment and equity on a global level. UNESCO's Institute for Statistics (Sherman & Poirier 2007) recently published a book that compares education equity among 16 of the world's largest countries. Although the focus of this UNESCO volume was limited—using access to formal schooling and allocated resources to education as operational definitions of equity in the case countries—the selection of this topic by UNESCO emphasizes the urgency of education inequality analysis by and for educators, researchers, and policy makers. The World Bank's *World Development Report* (WDR) features a global development issue thought to be especially timely. The WDRs are generously funded and typically of high professional rigor. The discipline of economics is always well reported as expected. The WDR for 2006, in a line of such reports dating back to 1978, is titled *Equity and Development*. Equity or equality and its ubiquitously maligned antonym, inequality, is a theme that appears with uniform regularity in the publications of major development agencies as well as finding a home in the development prospectus of the smallest nongovernmental organizations. Linking equity to development in the title of the WDR 2006 will provide grist for the mill of only the most hardened of World Bank critics. Like us, many development professionals recognize the World Bank, with its enormous reach and prestige, for placing equity front and center on the development stage.

But why the urgency now? And, in any case, should our concern with equity go beyond the ideal of social justice to the heart of a development agenda? What is the known relationship, if any, between equity and development? And what role, if any, does inequality in educational attainment or learning achievement play in a nation's development ranking?

We take up most of these issues in this volume. Our concern is with one kind of inequality, namely, education inequality. The WDR for the first time

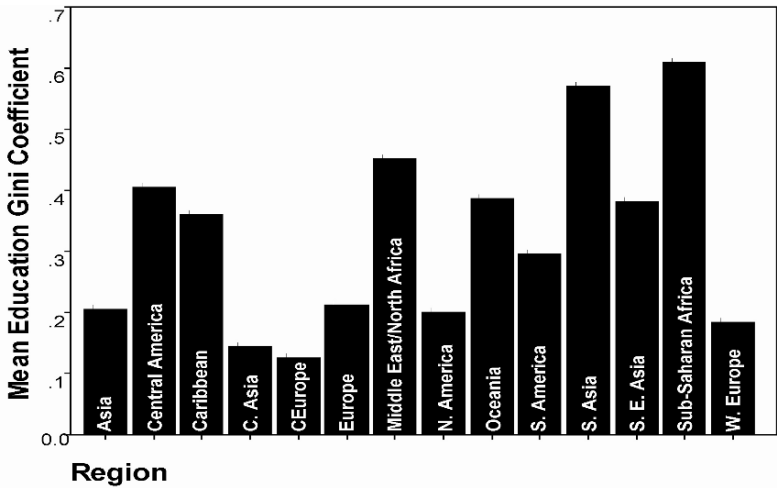
moved beyond the question of the inequality of wealth, to the significance of inequality in the production of human capital.

Table 1.1 draws from data in the WDR's Table A4 (pp.284-285) and is of immediate interest in this respect. The table shows a new data set assembled from individual-level records of various household surveys across 124 countries, showing various measures of inequality in educational attainment in the labor force, that is, among the population past school age. The major headings of Table A4 demonstrate an analytical approach to the topic and also reveal the expected co-variants of education inequality. These headings include:

- Share of the population with no schooling, 1-6 years, 7-12 years, or 13 or more years of schooling.
- Mean years of schooling among urban vs. rural residents, and among men vs. women.
- Two statistical measures of inequality in schooling attainment, including the Gini index or Gini coefficient which measures the gap between the actual distribution of education attainment and full equality.

As we begin our introduction, we ask the reader to examine Figure 1.1 below which is our reconstruction of data from the WDR graphically depicting the worldwide distribution of the education Gini coefficient.

Figure 1.1: Distribution of the Education Gini Coefficient



The figure leaves little doubt that education inequality is highly variable in today's world, thus inviting an explanation to account for this variation. We obtain some clues as to the range of possible explanations from this figure and other data in Table A4 where striking patterns may be observed:

Table 1.1: Global Education Statistics and Inequality Measurements, Select Countries

Survey Year	Share of total population by years of schooling					Mean years of schooling				Education Inequality Measures			Share of Inequality Attributable	
	0	1-6 years	7-12 years	13 or above	Total	By location			By gender	Gini Index	GE (0.5)	To location	To gender	
						Urban	Rural	Male						
Brazil	2001	0.20	0.21	0.23	0.36	8.38	6.61	8.44	8.32	0.39	0.53	0.01	0.00	
Cambodia	1999	0.00	0.63	0.36	0.01	5.70	7.12	5.52	6.35	5.15	0.28	0.12	0.04	0.04
Cameroon	1998	0.32	0.29	0.30	0.08	5.32	7.58	4.14	6.54	4.27	0.50	0.84	0.05	0.03
China	2000	0.07	0.33	0.55	0.05	6.54	8.53	5.18	7.22	5.82	0.37	0.35	0.08	0.02
Egypt, Arab Rep.	2000	0.35	0.19	0.28	0.17	6.60	8.60	4.83	7.90	5.28	0.51	0.90	0.95	0.02
France	1994	0.20	0.12	0.48	0.20	8.26	8.58	7.36	8.24	8.28	0.37	0.49	0.00	0.00
Ghana	1998/1999	0.31	0.14	0.41	0.14	6.62	8.79	5.39	8.31	5.22	0.46	0.78	0.04	0.04
India	1998/2000	0.41	0.20	0.31	0.08	5.03	7.78	3.93	6.50	3.57	0.56	1.02	0.05	0.04
Kenya	1999	0.20	0.26	0.52	0.02	6.26	8.05	5.48	7.01	5.56	0.38	0.51	0.03	0.01
Lesotho	2000	0.15	0.39	0.42	0.03	5.82	..	..	..	..	..	..	..	..
Malawi	2000	0.30	0.40	0.30	0.01	4.23	7.67	3.60	5.46	3.08	0.52	0.80	0.06	0.05
Mexico	1999	0.08	0.41	0.37	0.14	7.78	8.63	4.67	8.10	7.49	0.34	0.30	0.09	0.00
Mozambique	1997	0.48	0.43	0.08	0.00	2.24	4.64	1.54	3.2	1.45	0.65	1.27	0.11	0.06
Namibia	2000	0.20	0.23	0.53	0.04	6.65	8.29	5.35	6.73	6.57	0.38	0.52	0.05	0.00
Nicaragua	2001	0.23	0.41	0.26	0.10	5.57	7.28	2.91	5.54	5.59	0.49	0.67	0.13	0.00
Nigeria	1999	0.39	0.23	0.28	0.11	5.77	8.06	4.77	7.06	4.61	0.53	0.97	0.03	0.02
Peru	2000	0.08	0.32	0.39	0.21	8.76	10.24	5.56	9.51	8.03	0.30	0.26	0.14	0.01
Sierra Leone	2000	0.74	0.04	0.19	0.03	2.44	..	..	..	..	..	..	..	..
South Africa	1998	0.74	0.14	0.09	0.03	1.95	3.93	0.58	2.72	1.33	0.79	2.10	0.19	0.11
Swaziland	2000	0.20	0.24	0.52	0.04	6.78	..	..	..	..	..	..	..	..
Taiwan, China	2000	0.05	0.22	0.47	0.26	9.48	9.74	7.03	10.15	8.84	0.30	0.24	0.02	0.01
Tanzania	1999	0.30	0.19	0.50	0.01	4.58	6.03	4.05	5.36	3.93	0.41	0.74	0.02	0.02
United Kingdom	1999	0.00	0.00	0.68	0.31	12.16	12.31	11.98	12.21	12.11	0.11	0.02	0.00	0.00
United States	2000	0.00	0.02	0.42	0.55	13.83	13.96	13.37	13.85	13.80	0.13	0.04	0.00	0.00
Uganda	1995	0.32	0.39	0.27	0.03	4.23	7.53	3.71	5.46	3.12	0.50	0.82	0.05	0.05
Vietnam	2000	0.06	0.34	0.57	0.02	6.96	8.48	6.44	7.43	6.53	0.28	0.22	0.04	0.01
Zambia	1992	0.16	0.30	0.49	0.06	6.26	8.45	4.91	7.41	5.14	0.37	0.44	0.08	0.94
Zimbabwe	1999	0.10	0.21	0.62	0.07	7.57	9.52	6.22	8.41	6.81	0.30	0.30	0.08	0.02

Source: The World Bank, World Development Report 2006: Equity and Development (New York: Oxford University Press, 2006, pp. 284-285).

- The first nine most unequally distributed countries are all in Sub-Saharan Africa (SSA); the 21 most unequally distributed are all in either SSA or Asia-Near East. The most unequally distributed countries among Latin American countries, Haiti and Guatemala, come in at 21st and 25th in this global ranking.
- In general, overall inequality in education is highly correlated ($r = -.93$) with low overall school attainment, or number of years of education completed. In the most unequally distributed country, Burkina Faso, 86% of the population beyond the usual school age had no schooling at all. Many of the countries for which no data were available on schooling inequality also had very low levels of overall attainment.
- The range of inequality in schooling attainment across countries is much greater than the range of inequality in income or consumption (not shown). Burkina Faso has the greatest inequality in schooling, with a Gini coefficient of 0.90; at the low end, the US and several countries in Western and Eastern Europe have schooling Ginis in the 0.10-0.13 range. In contrast, the Gini Index for income inequality is much more compressed, ranging from 0.59 in a notoriously unequal country like Brazil [and a bit higher in Haiti (0.68) and Botswana (0.63)], down to a minimum of 0.25 in Sweden.
- The table contains a statistical decomposition of schooling inequality into the portions attributable to rural vs. urban residence, and that portion attributable to gender. In general, the rural-urban portion is substantially higher than the gender gap. Just as striking, the share of both these attributes in total schooling inequality tends to be rather small, suggesting that the main factors explaining schooling inequality lie elsewhere (e.g., in household income and other measures of socioeconomic inequality).

Defining Equity and Equality

At the outset of this book, it is important to define the key and underlying terms interwoven throughout the volume. While contributing authors provide multiple and, in some cases differing or conflated definitions, we want to provide in this introductory chapter distinctions as we view them between the terms *equity* and *equality*. We thus define equality as the state of being equal in terms of quantity, rank, status, value, or degree. Equity considers the social justice ramifications of education in relation to the fairness, justness, and impartiality of its distribution at all levels or educational subsectors. Both terms are the focus of this book and are examined under multiple and sometimes comparative international contexts.

A review of prominent historical equality and equity works include the

writings of James S. Coleman (1966, 1968); Martin Bronfenbrenner (1973); Aletta Grisay (1984); Gewirtz, Ball, and Bowe (1995); and Joseph P. Farrell (1999). Five definitional types of inequality are identified by Coleman (1968) in his *Harvard Educational Review* article: (1) differences of the communities inputs to the school; (2) racial composition of the school; (3) various intangible characteristics of the school; (4) consequences of the school for individuals with equal backgrounds and abilities; and (5) consequences of the school for individuals of unequal backgrounds and abilities (pp.16-17). Bronfenbrenner (1973) notes that equality refers to quantity and equity refers to the fairness or social justice of the distribution of education. Grisay (1984) discusses five principles of educational equality: natural equality principle, equality of access principle, equality of treatment principle, equality of achievement principle, and the post-modern principle. Gewirtz et al. make a distinction between these two terms and define equality as a matter of education based on facts and equity as a matter of education based on values. Farrell (1999) largely supports Bronfenbrenner's definitions yet also recognizes that these definitions may very well differ depending on individual, subgroup, or group perspectives.

Scholars have identified factors that lead to or perpetuate inequalities in education, including but not limited to opportunities for educational attainment (Breen & Jonsson 2005; Connolly 2006; Shavit & Blossfeld 1993), culture (Bourdieu 1977; Reagan 2005; Reay 2004), disabilities (Carrier 1986; Peters 2003), gender (Stromquist 2005; UNICEF 2007), globalization (Carnoy 1999; Rambla 2006), HIV/AIDS (Jacob & Collins 2008; UNAIDS/UNESCO 2005), language (Brock-Utne 2007; Hungwe 2007), natural disasters (Gitter & Barham 2007; Skoufias 2003), neoliberalism (Apple 2001, 2005; Colclough 1996; Her shock, Mason & Hawkins 2007), political economy (Collins 2004; Holsinger 2005), politics (Dale 1989; Marginson & Mollis 2002), poverty (Narayan 2000; Reimers 2000), privatization (Belfield & Levin 2002; Geo-JaJa 2004; Torche 2005), race or ethnicity (Ogbu 1988; Persell, Arum & Seufert 2004; Phalet, Deboosere & Bastiaenssen 2007), religion (Driessen 2002; Mehrotra & Panchamukhi 2006), social class (Erikson & Goldthorpe 1992; Jonsson, Mills & Müller 1996; Persell 1977; Stromquist 2004), societal values and norms (Foster, Gomm & Hammersley 2000; Goddard 2003), socioeconomic status (Ellwood & Jencks 2001; Filmer & Pritchett 1999; Treiman & Yip 1989), standardized tests (Baker, Goesling & LeTendre 2002; Freeman 2004; Reimers 2000), and war (Davies 2005; Nafziger & Auvinen 2002; Stewart, Humphreys & Lea 1997). The chapters appearing in this volume do not address all these factors and the myriad issues arising from them. They do touch on many of them, however. Our conclusion is that no single factor can ultimately explain the local, regional, or national disparities associated with education in a given country and in most cases a multivariate explanation is required to portray the complexities associated with the inequalities of education.

Several methods are employed in this volume for measuring education equality and equity, including the measurement of educational attainment, distribution, planning, and stratification. In addition to this initial chapter, seven others include the education Gini coefficient¹ as a means for measuring attainment, giving the volume a unique and comparative look at national education systems. In addition, several chapters disaggregate the education Gini findings to county and province levels, which provide insights into the various causes of existing and projected inequalities in education. The education Gini coefficient measures the distribution of education and calculates an index of educational inequality. The larger the Gini coefficient, the less equal the distribution; that is, the Gini coefficient ranges from 0 (perfect equality) to 1 (perfect inequality). The education Gini coefficient can be graphically displayed using a Lorenz curve.² In addition to the education Gini coefficient, Thomas, Wang, and Fan's Chapter 2 also uses the education Theil index for comparing the distribution of educational attainment across countries over time.³

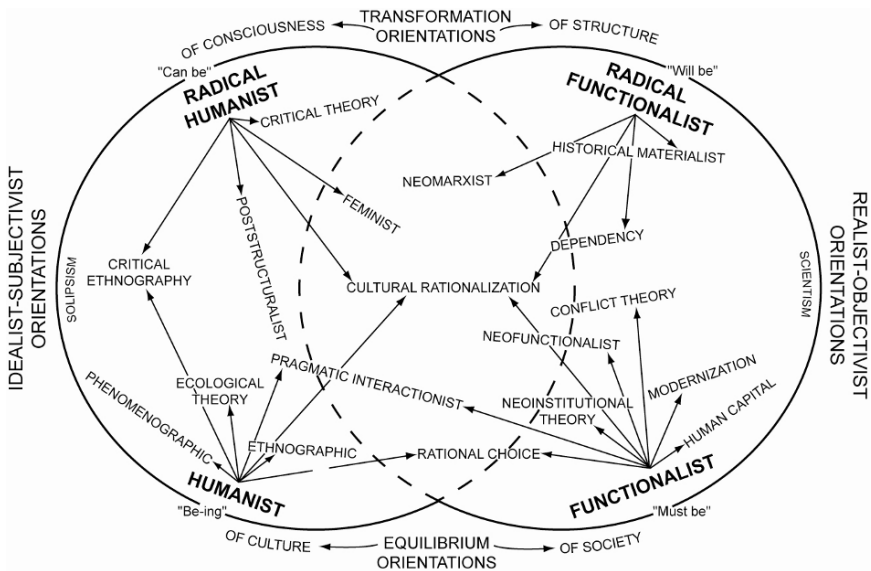
While quantitative findings are helpful and shed light on national education contexts, an overemphasis on statistics limits scopal analysis. We agree with John W. Tukey (1977) who recognizes that an over reliance on statistical hypothesis testing often conceals underlying or hidden variables in an analysis, particularly relevant while examining the inequalities in education. Rather, additional methods of triangulation or support (e.g., by employing exploratory data analysis [EDA]) are needed to provide qualitative description based on contextualization of the educational phenomenon. Many of the chapters in this volume provide examples of triangulation and multivariate analysis to examine the dynamics and variations of education within and between countries. These methods of measuring the inequalities in education have theoretical underpinnings which is the focus of the next section of this chapter.

Setting the Theoretical Stage for the Inequalities of International Education

Theoretical frameworks for mapping societal phenomena and change are as diverse as the factors that lead or contribute to the inequalities in education. Rooted in the social sciences, several founding theorists and scholars have contributed to this theoretical cartography (Paulston 1996). We would like to identify several of the major theoretical paradigms used by scholars, including the contributors to this volume, as a means of introduction rather than advocacy. In providing this theoretical introduction, we recognize both the strengths and weaknesses of various theoretical perspectives and ultimately take more of an eclectic theoretical stance that is largely determined by the dynamic education needs or topic of study associated with local, national, or international context/s (i.e., taking into account cultural, economic, historical, political, and social circumstances).

We also feel it necessary to provide a framework of theoretical dialectics that rise in opposition to one another, highlighting the ability of the examination of inequalities from a number of theoretical lenses. Paulston (1994, 1996, 2000), along with Jacob and Cheng (2005), examined social theories in relation to the field of comparative, international, and development education from dialectical and hemispherical perspectives that follow both linear (two-dimensional) and circular (three-dimensional) patterns or maps. Figure 1.2 portrays the dialectical subjective (solipsism) and objective (scientism) theoretical hemispheres along the x-axis and the equilibrium and transformation orientations along the y-axis.

Figure 1.2: A Macromapping of Paradigms and Theories in the Comparative, International, and Development Education Field
Adapted from Paulston (1994, p.931).



By linear pattern we mean that the theoretical landscape has evolved over time with a theoretical nexus forming after World War II in the area of international and development education. Framed largely within a Cold War context, the development education theories that arose during this period corresponded in many ways with political and economic ideologies advocated by the super-powers of that era. Steeped in the “development” rhetoric of the Cold War Era, functionalist theories (modernization and human capital) prevailed in the general international development arena in the 1950s and increased in momentum over the next quarter century (Collins 1971; Inkeles & Holsinger 1973; Inkeles & Smith 1974; Parsons 1959; Shultz 1961). Almost from the onset, functionalist theorists began

facing increasing opposition from scholars and policy makers who offered counterbalance perspectives as a response to what the functionalist critics viewed as the emergence of a primarily neoliberal theoretical framework. Functionalist critics were supported by decades of limited international development education success stories and failed education efforts in other national contexts. This paradigm shift fueled the rise of conflict, dependency, world systems, and neo-Marxist theories in the Radical Functionalist quadrant of Figure 1.2 (see Cardoso & Faletto 1979; dos Santos 1976; Frank 1975; Ritzer & Schubert 1991; So 1990; Vengroff 1977; Wallerstein 1974). The Radical Humanist Quadrant, with its multiple critical theories (including critical literacy, critical race, feminist, and postmodernist theories), came to the forefront of international development education theories in the 1980s but has roots in much earlier works (Freire 1970; Giroux 1983; Habermas & Ben-Habib 1981; Harding 1998; Kellner 2000; Solorzano 1998). Finally, the Humanist Quadrant of Figure 1.2 contains current theories associated with ecology, ethnography, and phenomenology (Bronfenbrenner 1976 and 1979; Geertz 1988; Hammersley 1992; Hamrick 1985). Neoinstitutional theory, as advocated by John Meyer and others (Meyer, Boli, Thomas & Ramirez 1997; Schofer, Ramirez & Meyer 2000), joined the Functionalist Quadrant in the 1990s and provided assistance in examining other factors that may temporarily hinder economic development in the short run (such as advocacy for human rights and social justice) but recognized its importance in sustainable development.

By circular pattern we offer an alternative to the linear or chronological development education theories that are largely rooted in traditionally Western or dominant societies. This circular pattern also allows researchers to examine an educational phenomenon from a three-dimensional, spherical standpoint where any number of qualitative perspectives from different standpoints along a spherical surface can examine the educational phenomenological core. Theories that fit within this circular cartography include critical theories, ethnography, ecological theory, and phenomenology.

Organization of This Book

In addition to some new materials of our own, the purpose of this chapter is to introduce the balance of the volume and to direct the reader to topics of greatest interest. As is appropriate in edited works, this one has an organizational logic. We present chapters both by region and by themes. While the regional organization is self-explanatory, the thematic aspects are perhaps less so.

We have grouped the chapters into two primary sections: conceptual issues and geographic regions. Six chapters address specific conceptual issues that range from global trends and comparisons of inequality to specific topics such as how capitalism, gender, disabilities, and language influence and affect overall education inequalities. Sixteen chapters are arranged into five major geographic

regions: Asia, Europe, North Africa and the Middle East, North and South America, and SSA. These chapters provide national case studies that address a number of issues relating to education and inequality. Five chapters provide comparative studies between two or more nations. In this introductory chapter, we have identified several education inequality themes that have emerged over the conceptualization process of this volume which are detailed in this section.

Theme 1: The Concept of Inequality as Applied to Education

Education is often viewed as a key catalyst for overall individual, community, and national development (see for instance, Sen 2000; Bowles & Gintis 1976). Human capital theory was based on this notion and was critiqued through countless studies over the past half century (Baker & Holsinger 1996; Diener & Dweck 1978; Harber 2002; Lane 2001). Achieving equity in education quality, opportunities, and outcomes have long been objectives of national governments and donor agencies. Billions of dollars have been committed to helping the world's poor help themselves. Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) countries devote large amounts of public and private funds to local and national education efforts in all education subsectors. However, development education efforts have often been unsuccessful and lead to unforeseen repercussions including the paradoxes of underdevelopment or de-development. These repercussions inevitably harbor countless inequalities; hence, this volume discusses many of these paradoxes in multiple national settings and geographic regions. Inequalities in terms of educational opportunities and attainment, both within and among countries are examined.

Theme 2: The Measurement of Education Inequality

Measuring education inequality is not an easy task; scholars have attempted to do this for many years. In this volume, contributors provide multiple methods for measuring education inequality. These methods range from qualitative studies with students and teachers to economic analysis of attainment through the Theil index or education Gini coefficient. While no one method is recognized as the end-all solution to measuring education inequalities, these methods do provide us with a starting point for a sound foundation. We also recognize that there are multiple ways of viewing education and the inequalities of education. It is not the intention of this volume to advocate one method of measurement over another; rather we are set on highlighting a variety of measurement possibilities for educators, researchers, and policy makers in examining blatant and, in many cases, hidden inequalities associated with education. It is thus our explicit intent to include differing methodological approaches for examining educational inequalities. We feel that rather than detracting from a singular measurement medium, these multiple approaches strengthen the overall volume.

Several chapters examine differing methods for measuring education inequality. Thomas, Wang, and Fan (Chapter 2), Wu (Chapter 4), Collins (Chapter 8), Rew (Chapter 13), Crouch, Gustafsson, and Lavado (Chapter 20), and Unterhalter and Oommen (Chapter 23) contribute conceptual chapters and case studies through measuring education inequality on national, regional, and global levels. Others, such as Deer (Chapter 14), Johnson and Howard (Chapter 19), and Meek and Meek (Chapter 22) provide descriptive critiques of education inequality based on the literature and governmental policy analysis. Still others examine one, overarching issue—such as capitalism (Chapter 3), gender (Chapter 5), disabilities (Chapter 6), or language (Chapter 7)—from an education inequality lens. Several chapters also offer qualitative or mixed-methods analyses, including Megahed and Ginsburg's Chapter 16 and Kheiltash and Rust's Chapter 17.

Theme 3: The Relationship between Education Inequality and Economic Growth

There is a striking relationship between the education Gini and GDP per capita growth from 1990 to 1999. The table below illustrates this relationship by comparing fifteen Western European Countries with 36 SSA countries. The mean education Gini for Western Europe in 1999 was .18 whereas for Sub-Saharan African that same distributional figure was a very unequal .61. For the same decade the per capita income growth in Western Europe was a low but steady 2%. But in Sub-Saharan Africa the decade saw slightly negative (-0.41) per capita growth. Of course, we do not argue that the mere fact of the relationship is proof of a causal connection. Nevertheless, neither do we believe that this is a random phenomenon. Countries that have highly equitable distribution of human capital in their labor force are countries whose per capita incomes grow. High birth rates in Sub-Saharan Africa of course make it difficult to achieve equitable distributions of education and, at the same time, contribute to each individual having a smaller share of national wealth. The relationship around the globe between the education Gini and per capita income (1999) is also very high ($r = -.47$).

Theme 4: The Relationship between Inequality and Per Capita Income

The relationship around the globe between the education Gini and per capita income (1999) is also very high ($r = -.67$). Countries comprising the lowest tenth of all countries whose GDP per capita ranges from US\$100 (in Burundi and Ethiopia) to US\$220 (in Rwanda) have a very unequal distribution of education in their respective labor forces (.71). Sharply contrasting with these are the countries in the top tenth whose education Gini is a very equal .13. Again, while we are in no position to say that this relationship is causal, we are reminded that all causal relationships are highly correlated. This degree of association is well beyond a chance expectation. What is it then that is at work here? Does the relationship

Table 1.2: Relationship of Education Gini to GDP Per Capita Growth

Western European Countries				
Country	Education Gini		GDP per capita growth 1990-1999	
	Coef.	Rank in 128	Rate	Rank in 128
Austria	.14	16.0	1.4	54.0
Belgium	.22	38.5	1.4	54.0
Denmark	.11	4.0	2.0	39.0
Finland	.15	19.5	2.0	39.0
France	.37	66.0	1.1	61.5
Germany	.25	47.5	1.0	64.5
Ireland	.11	4.0	6.1	3.0
Italy	.23	41.0	1.2	58.5
Luxembourg	.21	35.5	3.8	12.5
Netherlands	.13	12.0	2.1	35.0
Norway	.11	4.0	3.2	17.5
Spain	.31	57.5	2.0	39.0
Sweden	.16	22.5	1.2	58.5
Switzerland	.13	12.0	-.1	78.5
United Kingdom	.11	4.0	2.1	35.0
(mean)	.18	25.6	2.0	43.3
Sub-Saharan African Countries				
Country	Education Gini		GDP per capita growth	
Angola	NA	NA	-2.8	102.0
Benin	.75	103.0	1.8	44.0
Burkina	.90	111.0	1.4	54.0
Burundi	NA	NA	-5.0	110.0
Cameroon	.50	81.5	-1.5	98.0
Central	.66	95.0	-.3	84.0
Chad	.86	108.0	-.9	94.5
Comoros	.71	99.0	-3.1	105.5
Congo, DR	NA	NA	-8.1	114.0
Côte d'Ivoire	.68	96.0	.6	71.5
Ethiopia	.83	105.5	2.4	28.0
Gabon	.39	73.5	.6	71.5
Gambia	NA	NA	-.6	92.0
Ghana	.46	78.5	1.6	47.5
Guinea	.84	NA	1.5	99.0
Guinea-Bissau	NA	107.0	-1.9	50.0
Kenya	.38	70.0	-.3	84.0

Table 1.2: Relationship of Education Gini to GDP Per Capita Growth (Continued)

Sub-Saharan African Countries				
Country	Education Gini		GDP per capita growth	
Lesotho	NA	NA	2.1	35.0
Madagascar	.31	57.5	-1.2	97.0
Malawi	.52	84.0	.9	67.0
Mali	.87	109.0	1.1	61.5
Mozambique	.65	94.0	3.8	12.5
Namibia	.38	70.0	.8	69.0
Niger	.88	110.0	-1.0	96.0
Nigeria	.53	85.5	-.5	88.5
Rwanda	.55	88.0	-3.0	104.0
São Tome	NA	NA	-.9	94.5
Senegal	.83	105.5	.6	71.5
Sierra L	NA	NA	-7.0	113.0
South Africa	.79	104.0	-.2	81.0
Swaziland	NA	NA	-.2	81.0
Tanzania	.41	75.0	-.1	78.5
Togo	.62	92.0	-.5	88.5
Uganda	.50	81.5	4.0	9.5
Zambia	.37	66.0	-2.4	101.0
Zimbabwe	.30	54.0	.6	71.5
(average rank)	.61	89.0	-0.41	76.9

work the other way? That is, are wealthy countries more able to afford the delivery of education services to all their citizens than poor countries, which are forced to decide among competing demands on the national treasury? Or are countries like Vietnam, for example, that are poor but have nevertheless made equal education access a high national priority, experiencing more productive labor forces that lead inexorably to higher per capita wealth? Or, are both directions simultaneously at play?

Theme 5: Changes and Trends in Education Inequality

More people gaining access to primary, secondary, and higher education that should translate into greater educational equality and equity is not necessarily the case. Critiques often describe educational advances as perpetuating a vicious cycle of education inequalities (Hershock, Mason & Hawkins 2007). David Hill and colleagues in Chapter 3 of this volume address the issue whether capitalism ultimately leads to greater inequality. While evidence can be found in favor of and against this argument in the academic literature, our concluding chapter

highlights recent trends that support the view that inequality in the distribution of education (number of years of completed schooling, or, attainment) is correlated with inequality of student learning achievement. We argue in our concluding chapter that inequality in education leads to inequality in material well-being or, perhaps more precisely, the maintenance of existing income inequality.

Table 1.3: Relationship between Per Capita Income (2001) and Education Inequality

GDP capita range 2001 (USD)	Number of countries	Mean Ed Gini	SD of Ed Gini
0 – 219	9	.71	.24
219 – 318	11	.51	.14
318 – 448	9	.53	.23
448 – 642	10	.51	.24
642 – 1,190	11	.38	.15
1,190 – 1,750	12	.34	.18
1,750 – 3,097	12	.27	.13
3,097 – 5,566	11	.24	.07
5,566 – 26,297	12	.20	.08
26,297 – 46,000	11	.13	.03

Great strides have been made in eliminating some forms of education inequalities; however, many others remain. Income disparities, opportunity differences available to dominant and minority races and ethnic groups, and disabilities continue as limiting factors of educational progress in rural and urban settings (Goesling 2001; Reay 2004). Where achieving universal primary education eliminating illiteracy were once dual goals for many developing countries, a primary and, in many cases, a secondary-level graduation certificate is no longer sufficient to secure employment in an increasingly globalized work environment (Altbach & Peterson 2007; Döbert 2004; Haveman & Smeeding 2006). The horrific HIV and AIDS trend in Sub-Saharan Africa and elsewhere has left millions of children orphaned spans both genders, social classes, and ethnic groups (Morisky, Jacob, Nsubuga & Hite 2006). The MDGs were established to help realize education equality on a global scale and provide a benchmark for educational standards. Yet, in a world that revolves around a predominantly knowledge-based economy, education systems of yesteryear were not sufficient for the social needs and employment demands of today and in the future. The future of education requires what Hawkins (2007) calls a paradigmatic shift away from the negative aspects of neoliberal politics and economics and toward positive social change.

Theme 6: Race, Social Class, Disability, and Gender

Cross-cutting factors like race, social class, disability, and gender seem inevitably linked to the inequalities in education. Ever widening gaps between dominant and minority racial and ethnic⁴ groups continue to surface as contributors to education injustices and disparities (Aguolu 1979; Frisbie & Parker 1977; Gibson 1997). Politics is often at the root of racial tension, nurturing countless ethnic inequalities in developing countries' lengthy colonial histories and reverberating in most contemporary nation states (Blanton, Mason & Athow 2001). Linguistic genocide, loss of indigenous cultures, limited access to secondary and higher education, educational attainment, detribalization, and eventual assimilation into the dominant or hegemonic ethnic groups are among the many race-associated education inequalities that are discussed in this volume.

Closely linked to race and ethnicity is the term *social class*, another theme interwoven throughout this volume. We define social class in the traditional sociological manner as a grouping mechanism for which the basis of group membership is usually an ascribed or inherited characteristic that cannot easily be altered by the group member. Status, on the other hand, is an achieved characteristic that can be lost, gained, or modified within an individual's lifetime. Education status, for example, refers to the number of years of schooling completed, the final degree conferred, or the prestige of the degree-granting institution.⁵ Mary Ann Maslak's Chapter 10 examines distinctions in social classifications which is in part due to the imbedded and immutable caste system in many ways unique to the Indian case. Tyrone Howard and Eric Johnson critique the role of social class within the US education in Chapter 19. They focus on the negative aspects of a neoliberal system that permeates the US economy and which is supported by an education system that perpetuates social class inequalities.

An often neglected and marginalized factor associated with the inequalities of education is *disability*. While an entire chapter is devoted to this topic (Chapter 6), this is an area of significant dearth in the academic literature. Disability is a broad and overarching term that encompasses physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual disadvantages. Too often stigma and discrimination are among the inequalities associated with disabilities in education (Bagenstos 2000; Nsubuga & Jacob 2006).

Gender is a frequent topic of discussion within this volume and is examined from a variety of lenses. Contributing authors look at the trends of education inequalities between males and females in relation to educational attainment, access to higher education, and compounded with the disparities of minority ethnic status. Karen Hyer and colleagues examine multiple gender discrepancies as they relate to education on a global scale in Chapter 5 and offer suggestions for impacting policy and practice. Like race, social class, and disability, gender inequalities remain at the forefront of social justice in education debates at local,

national, and global levels (Seidman 1999; Shu 2004; Stromquist 1995). Where race and gender tend to be what Farrell (1999) considers “immutable and identifiable characteristics,” disabilities and social class are generally much less identifiable characteristics (p.158).

Summary of Book Chapters

The book opens with the authors’ seminal work, a continuation of their previous research that addresses education inequality (see for instance Thomas, Wang & Fan 2001, 2003). They, as much or more than any authors in the past decade, have contributed sound, economic justification for calling the distribution of opportunities the “key to development.” We lead with this piece because of its several foundational contributions to critical assumptions and factual arguments located throughout the balance of the volume, to wit: the concept of education inequality is explicated and methods for measuring it are reviewed and evaluated; the empirical case for a plausible causal connection between education inequality and economic growth is laid out; empirical evidence is provided for Amartya Sen’s now famous contention that is more the opportunities than resources or public expenditures that need to be equalized to produce optimal conditions for human progress and poverty reduction. The careful reader as well as the casual peruser of this volume would be well advised to pay attention to the section dealing with the analysis and measurement of education inequality because in these measures are buried the analytical tools that will help unpack the message found in later chapters. For example, the authors take pains to show how the education Gini can be estimated from the Lorenz Curve even for countries with large proportions of their populations with zero schooling. The reader is provided with a strong section on historical trends in education inequality but the major contribution may well be the concluding discussion concerning the role that the distribution of education may play in the contentious argument relating national education levels to economic growth and long-term poverty reduction.

For many readers, the answer to the question posed in the title of Chapter 3 is obvious and affirmative. For others, they hope that it is not true: they may even cite illustrations where countries with capitalist economies have made progress in flattening the education Lorenz Curve. Regardless of initial persuasion, David Hill, Alpesh Maisuria, and Nigel M. Greaves provide us with an opportunity to revisit a question that has been debated intensively in the past century. The leftist critique of education systems in capitalist societies maintains the central importance of social class and that case is laid out in Chapter 3. Hill and other authors maintain that Marxist thinkers have both the epistemic and explanatory advantage when analyzing modern social structures. The claim that education in the form of schooling as we know it today is functional to capitalism is sustained with two contentions. The first is that formal schooling ulti-

mately sorts children in a manner that is consistent with the hierarchical stratification of labor and the needs of employers. Individual needs are subordinated in this process. Second, schooling conditions the child to accept passively a lifetime of exploitation, differential treatment along ascribable lines and conformity. The conclusion, while not surprising, is cogently argued and forms an essential part of the discussion concerning education and inequality. Even if, as Hill et al. maintain, in the long term and in macro-political terms capitalism has led to increasing education inequality, we need to continually nudge ourselves to keep front and center the question whether this is an invariant relationship, or whether the advantages of capitalism can through the democratic political process produce more equal education outcomes.

Wu Kin Bing, an experienced World Bank education professional, drawing on data resources from around the world that are not available to most university academics, offers an extraordinary insight in Chapter 4 into the state of education worldwide with particular reference to inequality measures and trends. She begins by drawing attention to the large between-country variation in average years of schooling of the adult populations of several countries and causes us to consider the economic and social implications of such stark inequalities. This chapter goes beyond the empirical demonstration of inequality to a cogent discussion of its causes and in this sense makes a contribution not found elsewhere in this volume. Wu identifies, discusses, and provides evidence and relevant citations for a variety of factors affecting attainment outcomes including high inequality: out-of-pocket and often hidden costs of schooling, the discrimination and social exclusion found in class and caste systems, demand for child labor, parental education and the value parents place on education, gender and ethnic composition of schools, supply of classrooms, teacher knowledge of subject matter, female menarche, presence of toilet facilities in schools, tuition fees, and many others. The careful reader of this chapter will enjoy an up-to-date review of research findings dealing with the general problem of bringing education to all of the world's children and a careful elucidation of the factors that are keeping us from reaching this goal.

In Chapter 5, Karen E. Hyer, Bonnie Ballif-Spanvill, Susan Peters, Yodit Solomon, Heather Thomas, and Carol Ward address gender inequalities in educational participation. This chapter is the culmination of a gender equity conference that brought scholars together to discuss access to education, jobs, and political power, especially as they relate to the Millennium Development Goals and EFA initiative. The authors recognize that achieving gender parity remains a key education development issue. Hyer et al. highlight continuing education disparity: roughly two-thirds of the world's 862 million illiterates are female; and of the 150 million students enrolled in the primary subsector that will drop out, two-thirds will be girls. While female enrollments have increased over the years they are still far behind male enrollments in many regions. The authors contend

that the focus on enrollments alone provides a much too narrow assessment for reaching educational parity in future endeavors.. The second primary section of Chapter 5 provides a discourse analysis and critique of the progress of the two MDGs that deals specifically with education: to achieve universal primary education (Goal 2) and to promote gender equality and empower women (Goal 3). Hyer et al. give countless examples of verbal institutional and governmental commitments to achieving gender education equality, but the capacity for reaching these end goals is far from being realized. The authors conclude that while steps have been made in the right direction, much remains to be done.

In Chapter 6, Susan J. Peters draws our attention poignantly to the global agenda encompassed in EFA initiatives by demonstrating that the goals of poverty reduction and increased access to education cannot be achieved without addressing the education rights of 600 million disabled people worldwide, fully 70% of whom reside in poor countries. People with disabilities may account for as many as one in five of the world's poorest people. Peters describes the barriers confronting disabled and frequently poor people in achieving equitable access to education. Despite these barriers, a growing number of programs in countries of the South have begun to address effectively exclusion from education for disabled people. More importantly she systematically details the approaches adopted in many societies that include improvement in the rights of disabled people in mainstream development work. In particular, she outlines five principles that characterize effective approaches. The importance of this chapter lies not least in the obvious fact that the topic is too frequently overlooked or marginalized. The historical, cultural, economic and sociopolitical dimensions of exclusion and marginalization of persons with disabilities are staggering. Peters nevertheless remains optimistic and challenges the development community to examine her proposed way forward, a clear, achievable, holistic approach that builds capacities directed at both policy and practice.

In Chapter 7, Birgit Brock-Utne provides a critique of how European languages continue to pervade postcolonial African education systems and societies, leaving these nations in a perpetual "intellectual dependency" on their former European colonizers. Her argument—that the influences of an increasingly global economy and powerful bi- and multilateral donor agencies are the primary catalysts in the continued use of European languages in African education systems—is supported by a lifetime of personal experience (see for instance Brock-Utne 2000) and is grounded in a rich literature base of African language scholars. Language is at the heart of Africa's inequality, she contends. Approximately 90% of Africans have only cursory knowledge of their "official" national European language, "even though it is presumed to be the vehicle of communication between the government and its citizens," (p.173). Those who do gain mastery of European languages generally come from financially well-off families who can afford to send their children to private schools where the best

teachers and educational opportunities exist. This of course creates a great disparity and equity gap between the elite and the great majority of citizens. In addition, while many African languages are used in the primary education sector, most are not included in national curricula in the secondary subsector. The promulgation of indigenous African languages is accordingly stifled by the lack of government support and donor agency funding. Brock-Utne concludes that democracy in African societies cannot be achieved without leveling the language playing field.

Part II of this volume is constituted by six chapters which provide national case studies on six Asian countries: Cambodia, China, India, Republic of Korea, Taiwan, and Vietnam. In Chapter 8, John M. Collins addresses how access to the primary education sector has changed from 1998 to 2003 in Cambodia. Drawing upon data collected by the Ministry of Education, Youth, and Sports, Collins uses the education Gini coefficients of enrollment formula for analyzing education attainment for all 24 provinces and municipalities of Cambodia. Collins' findings indicate that challenges in achieving educational attainment parity remain, specifically with respect to issues of gender, urban-rural divide, and ethnic minorities.

In Chapter 9, John N. Hawkins, W. James Jacob, and Li Wenli provide an examination of subtle but persistent change involving a range of decentralization policies; a strengthening of legal foundations; improvements to governance at the center and institution levels and in between; questions about what to standardize and accredit (or legitimate) while leaving room for some regional and even institutional-level autonomy and creativity; and above all how to deal with the vast rural-urban divide. In presenting China's approach to its daunting education issues, this chapter contributes to an understanding of higher education in that country. This is, of course, a story in the making. Important decisions must still be made. How will China respond to pressure to vocationalize higher education? How will the country handle the inevitable question of naturally occurring variation in human abilities? Will Chinese higher education become increasingly elitist with a well-crafted façade hiding an elitist agenda? How will mass higher education be financed?

Mary Ann Maslak's Chapter 10 on enrollment and attainment in India provides a historical overview of that country's education sector and an education policy analysis based on a literature review. Maslak identifies a gap in the scholarly literature on Indian secondary and tertiary education subsector enrollment and attainment where a disproportionate number of studies target only the primary subsector as is the case in many developing country contexts. Groups who are particularly discriminated against in India include the aged, disabled, rural students, scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, and females. Based on 1991 and 2001 census data, Maslak provides a descriptive analysis of educational attainment, as determined by literacy and enrollment, and examines the data using a

gender parity index. She provides both a conceptual and an operational definition of educational equity. By conceptual educational equity Maslak notes that male and female students have equal opportunities for enrollment and completion. Operational educational equity refers to the planning, delivery, and evaluation of education services to “offer equivalent opportunities and experiences for males and females to meet educational goals” (p.255). Maslak’s findings identify multiple reasons for the under-enrollment of females at the secondary and tertiary levels. She concludes by challenging policy makers, educators, and scholars to reexamine the past in terms of gender and social constructivism and how these issues remain at the center of education inequality in India.

In Chapter 11, Matthew E. Burt and Park Namgi analyze the distribution of human capital in South Korea from 1970 to 2000 by calculating education Gini coefficients for each province and metropolis and each city, county, and ward. In doing so, the authors make a contribution to the literature dealing with human capital formation in that country. For reasons not difficult to imagine, South Korea has long been the object of inquiry by social scientists of various persuasions eager to uncover the secrets of its remarkable social and economic successes in such a short time. Burt and Park’s contribution consists in part in their use of the education Gini coefficient to measure the level of inequality in the distribution of human capital, as indicated by levels of educational attainment. They find that the aggregate national level of education inequality has fallen over the past 30 years. However, national indicators provide little or no practical insight into the important within-country differences that exist at lower levels of administrative division. Here the authors make their second contribution.

Burt and Park report for the first time that the level of education inequality in South Korea, as measured by the education Gini coefficient, fell significantly in all areas of the country between 1970 and 2000. The most significant decreases in most areas occurred between 1970 and 1980 between 1980 and 1990, and between 1990 and 2000 when a slowing down began as the Gini coefficients approached zero. Nevertheless, while inequality fell for both female and male populations in all areas of the country, Burt and Park find a clear advantage for males. The authors thus provide a fascinating historical overview of the development of education in Korea, detailing its remarkable success in increasing equality in the distribution of education during its period of extraordinary economic growth. In which direction does the causal arrow point? Burt and Park do not try to make this case. Rather they are content to conclude that educational policies in less-developed countries should focus resources in such a manner as to bring the entire school-age population into increasingly higher levels of educational attainment equally distributed among all subsets of the national population.

In Chapter 12, Hung Chih-Cheng and Cheng Sheng Yao tackle the issue of social justice in Taiwan’s rapidly growing higher education subsector. Along with this rapid growth come challenges in the nation’s stretch goal to provide

higher education for all those who are interested in attending. The authors identify factors that limit the participation of students from certain ethnic, gender, socioeconomic, and geographic backgrounds in Taiwan's elite higher education institutions. Hung and Cheng also provide definitions of equity and equality. Data for the authors' findings come from a questionnaire administered nationwide among higher education freshman students ($n = 33,959$, with a 68.5% response rate). These data enabled Hung and Cheng to examine the correlation between enrollment at the nation's top universities and student SES background, parental education level, ethnicity, gender, and geographic origins (whether they were from rural or urban settings).

An unequal distribution of formal education typically indicates that the enfranchised elite typically capture the benefits of education such as superior occupations and higher incomes. These are franchises that until recently all citizens of socialist Vietnam assumed they owned. W. Joshua Rew sets out to examine educational attainment in Vietnam in Chapter 13. In doing so, he provides us with insight into the economic and social context of Vietnam after several decades of post-American war economic growth and poverty reduction. Rew finds that while Vietnam as a national aggregate has a reasonably equal distribution of educational attainment, a considerable education inequality exists within and among provinces as well as ethnic and gender groups. The Vietnamese province with the highest Gini coefficient (i.e., the most unequal distribution of educational attainment) is Lai Chau (.53), whereas the province with the most equal distribution of educational attainment and the lowest Gini coefficient is Thai Binh (.18). Lai Chau's Gini coefficient is nearly three times the size of that of Thai Binh. This example alongside many others presented by Rew, provides ample reason to take national level education Ginis with some skepticism as to what they really tell us about the distribution of education within national boundaries.

Two chapters offer comparative education inequality studies in Part III on Europe. Cécile Deer's Chapter 14 provides a glimpse into one of the most enduring problems of modern European societies, namely, how centuries of social inheritance based on conditions conferred at birth or social class be overcome through modern egalitarian social policy. A central argument regarding the role of higher education has been to recommend that higher education be allowed to expand on the basis of academic performance. That argument is of course flawed in its assumption that the achievements of pre-university students do not depend on their social origins. The argument claims that allocating university places on the basis of secondary school performance is meritocratic and non-exclusionary. Deer points to several problems with this policy formulation. She contends that in England, relative success at upper secondary school level is in fact related to social position and, moreover, does not mean entitlement to a place at university as each institution of higher education remains free to select its students. The issues are as complex as the remedies proposed. Deer guides readers through the full

range of proposed reforms. These include those for vocationalization of the curriculum and academic specialization or streaming that aims to allow academic talent to be rewarded and university administrations to maintain control over their coveted role as guardians of scholarship while democratic social forces press inexorably for more egalitarian admissions policies. As Deer succinctly puts it, it is essentially the argument between the dons at Oxford and Cambridge and the Labour government. There are no easy answers to these vexing policy questions and centuries of a mentality of social entitlement based on family position.

Holger Daun provides the only contribution in this volume that addresses the relationship between religion and education inequality. Unlike earlier eras when each country could deal with its own education issues in something of a closed system, Daun argues that today education must be viewed in an increasing global context. This, he suggests, is certainly the case with religious education. Moral education is at the root of the contemporary trend toward religious demands for private education opportunities. In Chapter 15, Daun reviews the education context of 19 countries in the European Union (EU) both before and after the transition of national education systems into their current regional and global contexts. While the chapter discusses private and religious education, it details how the original Christian underpinnings of national education systems are giving way to institutions based in social imaginaries of economic competitiveness and human capital formation. Daun argues that one of the primary reasons behind the religious private school movement is a felt need to include morals and values in the curriculum. In an increasingly secular EU context, this curricular debate lies at the heart of European education. It also provides added support of the private school movement, especially in terms of private religious education. Considerable variance among European countries as to what can and cannot be taught in the national curricula largely determines what types of private schools can be established in the different EU countries. Daun notes how Muslim private schools do not always receive the same level of governmental support as other religious schools. Immigration is an important factor in achieving greater government support for Muslim private schools.

In Part IV on the Middle East and North Africa, two chapters discuss education inequalities in Egypt (Chapter 16) and Iran (Chapter 17). Nagwa M. Megahed and Mark B. Ginsburg's Chapter 16 offers a mixed-methods look at education inequality and attainment in Egypt. The authors' quantitative analysis draws on government and World Bank data sets as well as global Demographic and Health Surveys for comparative purposes. Stark differences are identified between urban and rural students and among differing family income groups. These two factors (urban location and socioeconomic status) prove to be critical in students' gaining access to academic secondary schools and eventually the higher education subsector. Qualitative interviews were conducted with 40 secondary school teachers from six randomly selected secondary schools in the Giza

governorate in 2000-2001. Teachers differed in their responses and presented both functionalist and conflict perspectives (as described by Paulston 1996 and Jacob & Cheng 2005) to describe education inequalities in Egypt. Megahed and Ginsburg's examination of education inequality in Egypt is strengthened by their combination of both qualitative and quantitative datasets and from contrasting insights from teacher perspectives assessing existing and future inequalities.

In Chapter 17, Omid Kheiltash and Val D. Rust take a very different methodological approach to issues of education equity to that taken by Rew and others who measure the education Gini index. Their country focus is Iran and the authors explore issues related to education equity with respect to gender, socioeconomic status, and religious and ethnic minorities. This they do by drawing on rich historical, political, and sociological evidence. Their treatment covers a range of education policies and practices such as the language of instruction, national curricula, and textbook content which the authors use as measures of educational opportunity provided to less-privileged and minority groups within Iran. They also explore the degree to which curricular content and pedagogy differ by minority and less-privileged groups. Among many reasons for the significance of this chapter is the fact that in Iran, as elsewhere in the contemporary Muslim world, the current educational system is a result of the transformation efforts of the theocratic regime that came to power following the Islamic Revolution of 1979. What followed was the intent to instill Islam as the national religion into every aspect of society including schooling. A major conclusion supported by the authors is that postrevolution educational policies are themselves instruments of certain kinds of social inequalities in that by purportedly treating everyone in the same manner, policies (unwittingly or not) advantage those whose language, gender, ethnicity, social class, and religion correspond to the Iranian ideal valued by the central government.

Four national and comparative case studies from North and South America comprise Part V of this volume, considering education inequality in Mexico (Chapter 18), the United States (Chapter 19), Peru (Chapter 20), and Brazil and Nicaragua (Chapter 21). Chapter 20 spans both Parts V and VI of this volume as it compares countries from both regions: Peru and South Africa.

Gladys Lopez-Acevedo's national case study on Mexico examines the evolution of education and inequality over the past two decades. From an earnings inequality perspective, Acevedo argues that while much has been achieved in terms of overall enrollment and attainment levels, wage disparity remains. Several measures were used including the Gini coefficient and $R_{10/20}$ and Theil T indexes. Findings from her study note that the gap between the rich and poor is increasing, as is education inequality. Globalization and its inevitable free trade agreements have taken their toll in increasing wage disparities. Lopez-Acevedo asserts that much of this disparity is the result of educational attainment levels, in that more highly educated workers tend increasingly to make more than less

educated workers.

From a critical social theory perspective, Eric Johnson and Tyrone Howard examine issues associated with education inequality in the United States in Chapter 19. Rather than focusing purely on outcomes, the authors consider the sources of education inequality by critiquing unequal institutional policies and structures. Johnson and Howard also critique the term *difference* and its relation to education inequality, especially how this concept changes to perpetuate social hegemonic status among groups. Marginalized groups that the authors argue are frequently affected by education inequality, including those identified by particular attributes of race, gender, ethnicity, sexual orientation, and class. When special attention, resources, and/or policy foci are diverted to one particular marginalized group (e.g., resources devoted to support students of Hispanic origins), other groups tend to become further marginalized or suffer from greater neglect. This notion creates a vicious cycle that the authors refer to as an *Oppression Olympics*, first coined by Elizabeth Martinez (see, for instance, Martinez 1993). The Oppression Olympics too often positions marginalized groups against one another. Underrepresented and marginalized groups need to work alongside and with each other and the dominant group/s to realize sustainable change in the US education system toward greater equity.

In their innovative analytical approach to education inequality, Luis Crouch, Martin Gustafsson, and Pablo Lavado focus on two societies located geographically at great distance from each other but each with long histories of statutory and nonstatutory apartheid. Moreover, while they draw on newly introduced inequality measurement methods, their application is also innovative in that they focus on the distribution of education outcomes such as learning achievement rather than on the final number of years of schooling completed. Among many novel approaches is the focus on the anomalous concept of government policy being characterized as “pro-poor” (i.e., in South Africa) even when government spending is 29% higher for wealthier families. In acknowledging a trend toward equalization of “input” resources for schooling, the authors are quick to draw attention to a troubling pattern of ever diverging schooling outputs. Still, the good news is that school outputs as measured by standardized achievement tests are more equal than the income distribution of South Africa giving rise to a more hopeful future for its society as a whole. Although the education expenditure equalization in South Africa is truly remarkable in both extent and in the short amount of time being taken to achieve it, the equalization of physical capital is a much more problematic issue. In the case of Peru, the authors analyze inequality of student learning achievement by reference to scores achieved in a national fourth grade examination of Spanish language. Like South Africa, in Peru there appears to have been in recent years a gradual decrease in regional learning disparities. But far more than in South Africa, wealthy Peruvian parents are likely to opt out of the public education system altogether. Household expenditure on

education is much higher in Peru than in South Africa. Crouch, Gustafsson, and Lavado's main finding is that learning achievement is far more unequally distributed than the distribution of inputs to schooling. Further, in both countries, learning is more equally distributed than income, a factor that the authors believe may bode well for the future.

In Chapter 21, Silvina Gvirtz and Lucila Minvielle's thesis—that civil society participation is a fundamental aspect in achieving democratic or equal education opportunities—suggests what is necessary yet insufficient to eliminate education inequality in Brazil and Nicaragua. Three case study locations are examined where government reforms are detailed as precursors to greater participation and democracy. Governance is also essential in realizing more democratic education systems. Gvirtz and Minvielle define three key aspects of school governance: *who* holds decision-making power, *what* issues are addressed and later established as policy, and *how* implementation of these decisions is achieved. These three aspects are used in Gvirtz and Minvielle's analytic framework for examining the effectiveness of democratic participation and governance in the three case study locations.

The final section of this volume, Part VI on SSA, includes one national case study on South Africa (Chapter 22) and another comparative case study of 19 Commonwealth countries in SSA. The second contribution dealing with South Africa (Chapter 22) offers a less technical treatment of the various forms of social inequality historically characteristic of that country. Christopher B. Meek and Joshua Y. Meek begin with the broadly shared hope that a postapartheid government would quickly move to put right past wrongs, particularly those dealing with equality of education opportunity. The reader is quickly led to face the unfortunate reality that although the structure of education has changed dramatically the fundamental facts of privilege based on race has been replaced with privilege based on relative wealth. Socioeconomic status has replaced race; the question remains whether that is a step in the right direction. After all, western scholars who pay attention to their own countries probably see much the same. The authors probe deeper, offering an interesting perspective on the practice and social impact of generations of apartheid policy in South Africa. They begin by telling the story of precolonial indigenous education. We are offered a rare glimpse into the structure and functioning of education before Europeans imposed a different formal education system that is just unlike the first. The former system had, after all, failed to prepare young Black children to serve the personal, familiar and financial interests of the new White colonial masters. Nowhere more so than in school financing was the nature of the new social order made clearer. Schooling for White youth was both compulsory and free, paid for entirely from the public treasury. Schooling for Black youth was not compulsory and, although infrastructure costs were funded by the government, the source of recurrent funding was strictly from a poll tax required to be paid first by every

Black adult male and later assessed on all Black females as well. Since the formal end of apartheid in 1994, overt racism has declined as a sorting mechanism socioeconomic status has emerged as a substitute for exploitative and discriminatory treatment. In the end, the authors find little reason for optimism about the prospects for decreasing inequality in the short-term future.

Chapter 23 draws on the earlier findings of Elaine Unterhalter, and other authors on the Gender Equality and Education Index (GEEI; see for instance Unterhalter, Kioko-Echessa, Pattman, Rajagopalan & N’Jai 2005). Elaine Unterhalter and Mora Oommen include data from 19 Commonwealth countries in SSA and advocate additional means of measuring gender education inequalities, as existing measures are simply inadequate. Use of the GEEI helps offset these deficiencies by including an attempt at examining people’s quality of life; however, the authors also recognize several limitations of the GEEI. The index takes into account primary subsector enrollment rates, grade-level retention levels (referred to by the authors as the “survival rate”), secondary level net enrollment ratio (NER), and a country’s gender development index (GDI). Recognizing these inherent measurement deficiencies, the authors identify several areas that need development in the future measurement of education inequalities, especially as they relate to gender.

Conclusion

The underlying themes of this book address the most significant issues facing education systems today, namely equality and equity of educational opportunities and outcomes. In this introductory chapter, we have provided a review of the literature and a definitional distinction between educational equality and equity. A review of the major theoretical frameworks in comparative, international and development education has been presented along with a critique of the negative and sometimes inevitable consequences of neoliberal-oriented politics, economies, and education systems. This emphasis on theory from the onset is supported by Kurt Lewin’s claim that “there is nothing so practical as a good theory” (1951, p.169). Six themes addressed in this volume were introduced along with some examples on a global scale followed by a summary of each chapter contribution.

Compiling the 22 core chapters of this volume was an immense undertaking that culminated with the collective efforts of some 41 international scholars and professionals. The authors’ commitments to analyzing and ultimately reducing the inequalities of education exemplify the importance of the book’s underlying themes, especially in relation to social justice issues in international education. This volume was not intended to be comprehensive, with respect to every aspect of education inequality—probably, no volume ever could be. Nevertheless, its intent is to provide an in-depth examination of key theoretical concepts,

measurement, and policy debate with conceptual and country case study examples. We hope that the chapters in this volume will provide educators, policy makers, and scholars with insights and examples in a global effort to overcome the inequalities in education.

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Notes

¹ Corrado Gini developed the coefficient that bears his name as a measure of variability of any statistical distribution or probability distribution (see Gini 1912, 1921; Dorfman 1979). Robert Dorfman (1979) documents the historical evolution and multiple use of the Gini coefficient and recognizes its most common use as a coefficient to measure income inequality. Chapters 2, 3, 8, 11, 14, 18, and 20 all provide definitions of the education Gini coefficient in relation to their respective chapters in this volume.

² The Lorenz curve is a graphical way to display the education Gini coefficient. If all individuals have hypothetically equal educational attainment, the Lorenz curve is a straight diagonal line (where x% of the population has reached x% level of educational attainment). This is called the line of equality. On the y-axis (vertical axis) it shows the cumulative percentages of the educational attainment held by the relevant percentage of the population that lie on the x-axis (horizontal axis). The more the curve diverges from the line of equality the more education inequality exists within the society. For more information on the Lorenz curve, its origins, and various uses, see M.O. Lorenz (1905) and Joseph L. Gatswirth (1971, 1972). Crouch, Gustafsson, and Lavado provide a sound definition of the Lorenz curve in Chapter 20 of this volume.

³ The education Theil index, originating from econometrician Henri Theil, is a statistic used to measure economic inequality. One of the advantages of the Theil index is that it is a weighted average of inequality within subgroups, plus inequality among those subgroups. For example, inequality within the People's Republic of China is the average inequality within each province, weighted by provincial income, plus the inequality among provinces. For more information on the Theil index, see Gary Fields (1980).

⁴ While the terms race and ethnicity are often used interchangeably, as is the case in several chapters of this book, we realize that several scholars maintain differing definitions unique to each term (see for instance Downey & Torrecilha 1994; Oppenheimer 2001; Paulston 1976; Sankar & Cho 2002; Singleton 1977). Generally speaking race is defined as a group of persons related by common descent or heredity. Ethnicity, at least in its original, anthropological definition, encompasses a much broader definition that includes the social and historical factors as explanations of group variations (Montague 1942).

⁵ Studies examining education and social class are in abundance in the comparative, international, and development education literature (see for instance Apple 2001; Burns 1963; Cox 1944; Osborn, Broadfoot, Planel & Pollard 1997; Sochet 1964).